Thursday, November 2

On the ground, the slugging goes on without any solution in sight. It is worrisome as such and because of the mounting number of hapless civilian victims. The knowledge that so many innocent Palestinians are caught in the rubble and getting killed cannot be sustained for much longer.

And we know nothing about the fate of the Israeli hostages (242, as of today). The United States will propose a pause in some of the fighting to allow delivery of humanitarian aid. The *New York Times* writes that Netanyahu is open to the suggestion. In Israel, this is denied. Secretary of State Blinken will meet tomorrow with the Israeli war cabinet. We shall hopefully know more by then.

American Jews are divided. The majority supports Israel unconditionally, but a growing number on the left have become increasingly critical, even extremely so. One hopes that Netanyahu knows what he is doing if he rejects even a limited pause. The total eradication of Hamas is an aim dictated by the desire for revenge, but one cannot eradicate an ideology, and a religious one at that. Netanyahu probably hopes to appear as the victorious leader in battle, something he has not achieved before. How much do personal calculations enter his "detached" assessment of the situation? Does the "war cabinet" have any influence on his decisions?

The ground operation goes on without any concrete details released, except that Gaza City is now completely surrounded. This of course means that the leaders of Hamas are in danger of getting caught. It probably explains the sudden trip by the political leader of Hamas, Ismail Haniyeh, to Tehran, obviously in order to ask Iran to induce its client, the Hezbollah leader, to intensify his military intervention. Indeed, Nasrallah is supposed to speak about the conflict tomorrow. He will most likely hint at what his organization plans to do and, indirectly, give some idea about Iran's intentions. The tension in the North is palpable, with the Israeli chief of